

Patty Hopkins: A Case Study in Gendered Erasure within British High-Tech

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In 2014, the BBC released material for their series titled "The Brits Who Built the Modern World", showcasing five architects who pioneered the British High-Tech movement. Missing from the image, however, was Patty Hopkins, a key architect whose skills helped push the very movement being celebrated. This essay uses that moment of erasure as a critical entry point to explore how female architects like Patty Hopkins have been consistently marginalized in architectural discourse. Through a close examination of Patty's career, publications, and media representations, and with the aid of Critical Theory and a first-hand interview with Dr. Deborah Benrós, this essay considers not just how erasure happens, but why, and what it tells us about systemic gender bias within the architecture profession.

An image taken by the RIBA for the exhibition "The Brits Who Built the Modern World," now part of the RIBA Archives, will be presented. We have Michael Hopkins, Nicholas Grimshaw, Norman Foster, Patty Hopkins, Richard Rogers, and Terry Farrell from left to right. A second image will be presented below the first. This is the one used by the BBC for their three-part series covering the exhibition, also titled "The Brits Who Built the Modern World." We have Michael Hopkins, Nicholas Grimshaw, Norman Foster, Richard Rogers, and Terry Farrell from left to right. It's nearly identical except that the only female architect is missing. The three-part series was released on February 13, 2014. Just under a month later, on March 5, 2014, the Architects' Journal pointed out that Patty Hopkins had been photoshopped from the image used in the series. As the title suggests, the exhibition and the BBC series focus on the British architects who pioneered the British High-Tech Architectural movement. The RIBA likely selected these six architects because they pioneered and nearly perfected the style.

This essay will examine Patty's work and contributions, comparing them to her recognition and representation, primarily through books, journals, and articles. The goal is to assess whether the British High-Tech movement provided female architects with the ideal platform to thrive, given its emphasis on rationality and technical clarity in design. Additionally, critical theory will be introduced to help explain not only Patty's exclusion but also the broader erasure of female architects from the field.

Critical Theory

Critical Theory first emerged in the early 1900s through the work of a group of German philosophers at the Frankfurt Institute of Social Research. They were interested in how systems of power shape our perception and understanding of the world. Over the century, it has expanded to include a wider array of groups, such as women, colonized people, queer and non-gender conforming individuals, working class citizens, since the field had originated primarily from white male figures.

At its core, Critical Theory is about questioning what is commonly accepted as true. It questions what is said, why, how these notions affect people, what is allowed to stay, and what gets erased. This is where it becomes particularly relevant to this essay. When Patty Hopkins is left out of journals, articles, credits, or images, it is not just a factual exclusion; it reveals something deeper about structural bias and who is permitted visibility and, frankly, a voice. Critical Theory helps unpack that: it gives language to patterns of exclusion that might otherwise seem like accidents or oversights. It also allows for multiple explanations to exist at once, which I will attempt to provide later in the essay.

British High-Tech

British High-Tech was deeply rooted in engineering principles, regularly embracing new technological advancements in construction methods and materials. Lightweight materials and structural systems, primarily steel and glass, became the movement's cornerstone. Beams, columns, cables, pipes, vents, and electrical systems are often exposed and celebrated. As Colin Davies put it in his book 'High Tech Architecture', "The High Tech architect sees architecture as a branch of industrial technology. He claims no social or artistic privileges. He wishes his buildings to be judged by the same criteria of performance as any of the other tools of everyday life. He wants them to be functional and efficient, not artistic or symbolic." The engineering-driven ethos of High-Tech meant that designs could be seen as rational and objective; neutral territory that could disarm critiques rooted in gendered tastes or "feminine" aesthetics. This was the optimal stage for female architects like Patty Hopkins to thrive and showcase their skills.

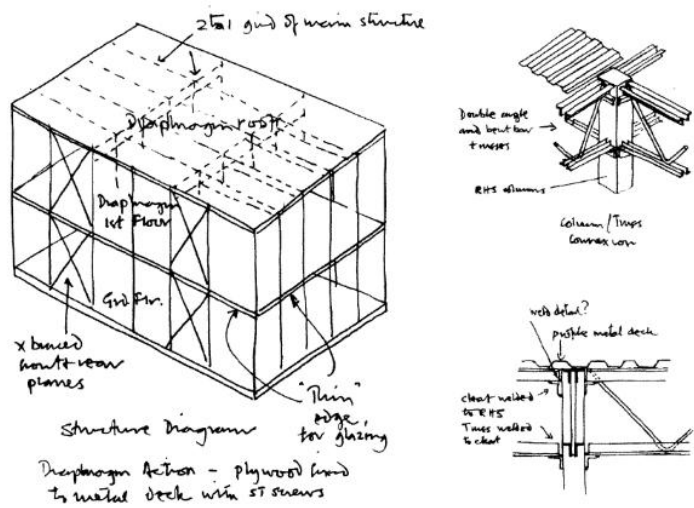
Patty Hopkins

Patty attended the Architectural Association in 1959 at the age of 17, having passed the entrance exam during her A-Level studies. She was one of five female students out of 60 to be accepted. At the time, the AA was still heavily focused on post-war redevelopment, as she says in an interview with the RIBA on February 16th, 2024. During her time there, she met her future husband, Michael Hopkins, and together they founded their practice in 1976. In the same year, they designed and constructed their house and studio, which is now infamously known as the ‘Hopkins House’.

The ‘Hopkins House’ is a primarily steel and glass building on a ten-by-twelve-meter plot of land in Hampstead, London. The Hopkins House, as Colin Davies put it in his book ‘Hopkins 2: The Work of Michael Hopkins and Partner’, “has become a classic... it is High-Tech applied in the domestic sphere.” While not being one of the earliest examples of British High-Tech, it is still known as one of the best examples because of its simplicity and efficiency, which helped refine and push the style forward, so much so that it became Grade II listed in 2018. It’s worth noting that Patty is not named in the titles of either Hopkins 1 or Hopkins 2. In Tony Hunt and Norman Foster’s book titled ‘Tony Hunt’s Second Sketchbook’, the architects were listed as “Mr and Mrs Michael Hopkins” above a sketch of the Hopkins House. In the RIBA Journal, where the house was showcased in April 2012, they not only refer to her as a wife, but her name is also misspelled as “Patti Hopkins”.

After designing and constructing countless projects such as the Schlumberger Research Centre in Cambridge (1985), Fleet Velmead Infants School in Hampshire (1986), the Bracken House Refurbishment in London (1992), and countless others before then, being awarded the RIBA Gold Medal in 1994. Even then, when awarded the Medal, The Architectural Review introduced the news by describing them as the “Husband and Wife team” along with Building Design pointing out that they were “the first RIBA Gold Medalists to kiss itself on stage” all while largely ignoring how or why they were presented with the award. Suffice it to say, there should have been no reason that Patty Hopkins would be seen or treated as inferior in any way; she was more than qualified, and she had shown her potential and her talents countless times after countless projects and awards.

Hopkins House, London

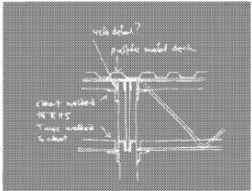


Hopkins House

London

Job: Hopkins House, London
Client: Mr and Mrs Michael Hopkins
Architect: Mr and Mrs Michael Hopkins
Date: 1976 – Built

- A two-storey steel frame building with profile steel first floor and roof decks
- Aim: to use a minimum number of small scale structural elements in a similar way to the Earnes house, California
- Off the shelf lattice beam elements not available so designed in house
- 2 lattice beam types, 1 perimeter beam, 1 column type and 1 X-tracing member
- First floor composite profile steel and plywood deck acting as a stiff diaphragm





[1] Hopkins Architects, Hopkins House, London, 1976



[2] Hopkins Architects, Schlumberger Research Centre, Cambridge, 1985



[3] Hopkins Architects, Fleet Velmead Infant School, Hampshire, 1986



[4] Hopkins Architects, Bracken House Refurbishment, London, 1992

Patera as a Case Study

In ‘Hopkins 2’, Colin Davies states, “It turned out there was, and always had been, much more to Hopkins than High-Tech. His work was changing... The extent of the development can be judged if we compare the prototype Patera industrial unit of 1982 with the Pilkington Laboratories at Sherborne School completed in 1999.” What is quite interesting is that Michael Hopkins appears to be given all the credit. Does he deserve it all? Was he the primary designer behind the Patera building system? What did Patty Hopkins contribute, if anything?

In ‘Hopkins 1’, Davies describes the Patera Building System as such: “Patera was conceived not as a single building but as a building system. The client, Nigel Dale, perceived a demand for small, standardised, single-storey buildings, suitable for industrial use or office use, which could be made as kits, delivered to the site in containers and erected quickly with minimal plant.”. In short, it was a new and innovative system for erecting a building structure in roughly 10 working days- that was its primary selling point. Patty is absent from the entire chapter on the building system, except for a small caption under an image that reads “Michael and Patty Hopkins’ own office in Marylebone, is a further stage in the Patera story...” Other than that passing reference, she’s effectively erased from the narrative.

The result is a natural assumption that she had little to do with the design, at least, that’s how it initially came across to me. But Patty did have a big part to play, and realistically, the system may not have been possible without her. As she says herself in an interview with the RIBA Journal released on February 16th 2024, “The practice expanded into a second studio up the road before finding a site in Marylebone, where we built our own office using the Patera steel system, which we had designed. We ended up buying the Patera factory – I ran it remotely when we were building the studio. I liked that – I enjoy doing practical things.”

To be fair to Colin Davies, ‘Hopkins 1’ was published in 1993 and ‘Hopkins 2’ in 2001. It’s possible he didn’t know the extent of Patty’s role, unless he had directly asked. Not one article or journal dating back to 1982 mentioned Patty even once when discussing the Patera

system. For example, when first published in the Architectural Review in January of 1982, the article starts with “MICHAEL HOPKINS ARCHITECTS: Industrial/Commercial units, Stoke-on-Trent, Staffs”. It then goes on to describe the system and construction, structure, and so forth. At the end, when credits are listed, it reads “Design team: Michael Hopkins, John Pringle; assistant, Peter Romaniuk.” The structural engineers are also included in the credits along with the client, Nigel Dale. But nowhere had Patty been mentioned, and this trend continues from there. The next publication of Patera was in the Architects’ Journal on September 1st, 1982 which starts as “Patera as a Process. The ultimate success of Patera will depend on matching the high quality hardware provided by Michael Hopkins Architects with high quality software, namely the support services.” It then goes on for 12 pages describing and showing in great detail the system from design, construction, connections, and fabrication through text, images, and drawings. Like the Architectural Review, at the end of the article, they give credits and it goes as such: “The Patera building, *for* Patera Products Limited, *by* Michael Hopkins Architects *design team*, Michael Hopkins, John Pringle (project architect), Peter Romaniuk, David Allsop, Chris Williamson”. It then, like the Architectural Review, credits the structural engineers, the client, and even the project partners. The system was then discussed in countless other publications- The Architects’ Journal (June 1, 1983; November 9, 1983), Baumeister (October 1987), among others- before eventually fading from the industry's focus.

Speculations

Many theories could try to explain this; critical theorists might say Patty’s erasure from the BBC Documentary wasn’t a mistake or oversight. They would likely say that it is just another example of the marginalization of the institutions historically run by and for men. They would point out that these bodies, such as the BBC, would either consciously or unconsciously portray the narrative that men made these architectural achievements. Gary Stevens, the author of “The Favored Circle”, would say something different. He would say that access to the architectural field’s highest levels is policed, and that only those within the favored circle are allowed in. He would say that the field is essentially a game of networking and social positioning. He would say that architecture is a field obsessed with individual genius myths, even though the field is highly collaborative. He also points out that the image of a married architectural couple would morph

into one, and usually, the male would take over as the one. Dozens more theories and theorists could be introduced and discussed, but the point is that nobody can truly say for sure why it was done or if there was any malicious intent behind it; speculations are all we have, but speculations can be specific.

This is just one case study from the Hopkinses; the firm has over 100 completed projects. Each of those projects would have dozens of articles, journals, and even book publications about them. To get a true understanding of Patty's erasure, a further, more meticulous analysis examining all the projects and all the publications about the projects would show and uncover the sheer scale of her exclusion. But rather than stating the obvious about how this is wrong and spending the rest of this essay pointing blame and speaking on behalf of female architects who must deal with the omission of rightfully earned credit, the rest of this essay will include an interview with Dr. Deborah Benrós. She is a registered ARB/RIBA Architect, the cluster leader of the Department of Architecture and Visual Arts at the University of East London, and a senior lecturer in Technical Studies and Representation at UEL. She has also worked in many firms over the years, most notably Foster and Partners, and Hopkins. Foster and Partners was one of the British High-Tech's so-called 'Big Four'. This gives the essay the perfect lens into the sphere of the British High-Tech as a female architect.

Interview

When you first saw Patty Hopkins edited out of the BBC image, what did it signal to you, not just about her, but about architectural history more broadly?

"I was outraged. I was really shocked. Especially because Foster is a very male-driven office. It's a thousand architects. Only 37% are women. When you go into the entry level, [there are] equal numbers of females and males. So, architectural assistants, you'll find a really good balance. But then, when you progress in your career and they start promoting you, there are more [male] associates than female associates, and then there's far more [male] associate partners than female associate partners. And then the ratio goes something like 80 to 20. Then partners, there's like 10% of female partners and 90% of male partners... When I was there, there were senior partners. There was not a single female senior partner. Seven, they were all male, they were all

white, and only one was not British. One of them was German. It's funny that you come to talk to me about this because myself and [a] friend, we started a thing called the 'Women's Network' at Fosters. When we were trying to sort of brainstorm about [why] women are not getting promoted, women are not getting to the high ranks. They were actually quite supportive, and right after we started the 'Women's Network', they started promoting [women]. The first woman they promoted was not an architect, was the person [who] does communications... Then they started promoting, finally, two female senior partners who were actual designers. and now you'll find far more. But 10 years ago, there was not a single senior partner, female... Very recent."

What kinds of omissions like this have you seen play out in architectural discourse, whether in media, academia, publishing, or even in your time in practice?

"They could have said the five practices that changed, the High-Tech. But no, they went into the five men who created High-Tech. It's very diminishing, especially because some of the first people doing High-Tech were 'Team Four'. 'Team Four' was half male, half female. They completely neglected the contribution of Sue Rogers and Wendy Foster. I think that's shocking. But that happens very often. I remember the controversy when they gave the Pritzker Prize... to [Robert] Venturi and they didn't give it to Denise Scott-Brown. Then, probably 10 years ago, people started campaigning to give the retrospective Pritzker to Denise Scott Brown, and they were against it. They didn't listen to anyone. I remember signing the petition, and I thought it would be such a nice gesture. Yeah, maybe we overlooked this female, who was also part of the practice and was a contributing part of the practice. Yeah, it happens a lot in our architecture, and it doesn't happen in other fields."

What's your take on Gary Stevenson's opinion that you must be within a certain circle to get to the top of the field, and that architecture is sort of obsessed with this solo male genius, even though the field is predominantly collaborative?

"I think it's sad. Few women broke [through] the glass ceiling. But unfortunately, when you look at them, like, for instance, Zaha, she didn't get married, have children, have a family, her life was her work. It seems like to get into that special circle, you do have to sort of let go of other things in your life. Well, men don't have to do that. It is true, and I think it's not only about being,

well, being male is definitely a driver, but also being in the right circles and being quite affluent and having the right network and going to the right school and having a sort of family background, not only socially, but economically, that puts you in the right places.

Are you optimistic for the future that these sorts of systemic barriers could be taken down? And where do you see the field going in regards to females?

“I am very optimistic. However, having said that, I sort of gave up a little bit. The reason why I left, I loved teaching, and I knew that at some point I wanted to do teaching. The reason why I left practice, specifically Fosters, was because I couldn't break [through] the glass ceiling. I had quite a nice career. I worked in interesting buildings, in big airports, and at the Apple campus, lots of really fun buildings. The minute that I got pregnant, they sort of put me [on] a little shelf and they said, “Ooh, you can't do these long hours anymore. You can't travel. You can't do this.” So I had to do this horrible project in India, commercial and disinteresting. Then I went a year off for maternity leave. When I returned, they put me in a suburban shopping mall in the US, a tough project that makes a lot of money, but you'll never see it published in magazines or books. I [was] many times overlooked for promotions, and I saw young female and male colleagues being promoted, and I was stuck in a place, and I had to make a decision. Do I get frustrated and be miserable and mope around, doing a job that I like, but not being recognized? Or do I move on? I just decided to move on. But I was very hopeful. That's why I stayed 10 years. I think you could see the changes, you'll see lots of female partners, definitely a massive increase because there was none. Things are changing. Not as fast as we would like it, but again, I think this generation is there's big hopes for this generation. Once you already started this movement, it's very difficult to stop; you can't go back. I'm very hopeful.”

Patty Hopkins' exclusion from the High-Tech story isn't an isolated mistake, it's part of a much larger pattern. From the Hopkins House to the Patera system, her work helped shape the movement, yet she's either been sidelined or left out entirely. As Dr. Deborah Benrós points out, this kind of marginalization isn't unique to Patty or to one time period; it's built into the structure of the profession. Yes, things are shifting, and there's some hope moving forward. But the field

still has a long way to go in owning up to how these stories have been told, and whose voices were missing from them. Looking at Patty's case is one way to start fixing that and moving toward something better.

Word Count: 3278 (excluding image captions)

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